sorties, which I flew with the commanding officer, Group Captain Sapre, who was cool, soft-spoken and relaxed. Flying with him was a welcome relief for someone who had learnt under two strict CFIs.

The only time I remember Assey Sir losing his cool with me was during the navigation phase of our training. In this phase, two pupils were to navigate using maps, and fly cross-country from one airfield to another. One pupil had to fly an onward sortie and the other the return sortie. The CFI grouped Anuradha and me together for this sortie and told me to perform well and show Anuradha a white demo. Since I had learnt quickly and thoroughly under him, complacency got the better of me and I became overconfident. Lack of preparation led me to perform one of my worst sorties in the navigation phase, so much so that Assey Sir was fuming during the entire fifty minutes of the sortie. He was so enraged in the end that he even snatched the controls from my hands. I was in tears. I knew I had let him down. Anuradha was equally confused. After the sortie was over, Assey Sir only called on Anuradha for a debriefing, while I was asked to wait outside his office. When Anuradha came out, I asked her if he had called me inside. She replied with a no. This worried me even more. When he finally came out of his office and saw me, he said, ‘Do you want me to debrief you for that pathetic sortie? There’s nothing I have to say. Go back and think about what you did and why you did it.’ I spent the night thinking about what had gone wrong. I knew the answer, but I was not quite ready to accept it—not until the next day, when I finally told the CFI that it was the result of my lack of preparation. A long lecture followed, a lecture that shook me nice and proper, and I decided to pull up my socks after the incident.

The second term of training and the first term at HTS were drawing to an end, and a curious air of nervousness filled the air. As the final test sortie edged closer, I spent my time revising whenever and wherever possible. On the day of my final test sortie, I went to the helicopter with Group Captain Sapre. In this sortie, a cadet would be given a few exercises and one or two emergencies to handle. Group Captain Sapre gave me quite a few exercises